

Google Cloud Print

Google's Cloud Print plans to enable any application on any device (desktop or mobile) to print to any printer via the cloud

Dye Sublimation

A printing process that uses heat to transfer dye onto a medium such as photographic paper or fabric using cyan, magenta, yellow colours and an overcoating layer



Ever since we have replaced film cameras with digital ones, physical photo albums have become a rarity. We present some photo printers that will help you rekindle that old tradition.

Nimish Sawant

nimish.sawant@thinkdigit.com

Photography has become accessible to everyone around us. We click more photographs now than we did say ten years back. But one common complaint we come across is that the photographs can only be viewed on a screen. That romanticism of actually touching real photo prints has definitely reduced since we decided to replace the camera roll with an SD card. How cool would it be to have the photo developing studio come to you than the other way round?

Photo printers are slowly but surely catching on. Every major printer manufacturer has some printer to address this growing need. We tested around 7 printers

(yeah we know that is not a great number). We contacted the respective brands well in advance, but with poor response as well as some damaged products dropped numbers. We managed to test one compact photo printer.

These printers are ideal to be used at homes or in small office setups. Not only do they print photographs, but can also be used for other work like printing documents or CD and DVD covers in some cases. The printers that we got for testing are quite different from each other in various aspects, where some can do WiFi, others come in wonderful form factors; some come with a modest two ink cartridges whereas some as many as eight.

Canon PIXMA iP3680

Canon PIXMA iP3680 is an inkjet colour photo printer. Its design is similar to other Canon PIXMA models like iP2680, iP1980 etc, coming in a rectangular box having rounded edges with a black glossy finish throughout. It's a practical design with just two buttons on the right hand rounded edge for power and cancelling printing. The iP3680 uses CMYK dye cartridge ink and a pigment black ink.



Canon Pixma iP3680

cartridge for high contrast text on a plain white paper. The build quality of the printer is quite decent. Tray quality is a bit poor as the hinges around it tend to shake a lot. It only has two connections viz: power connection and the USB interface.

After powering on the printer, the first task involves installing the five ink cartridges. Before installing the cartridges, you have to attach the print-head in the correct manner. While installing the drivers you get a prompt to test a print page for alignment of the printer head. As this is a photo inkjet printer, the glossy photo paper should be inserted from the rear side whereas the normal A4 paper should be fed via the cassette located at the base of the printer on the front side.

Opening the front panel opens up the output tray. The cassette has a capacity of around 150 pages. The output collector tray is located just above the base cassette and comes out in the form of a ramp. The iP3680 has support for PictBridge. It comes bundled in with its regular set of softwares like Canon Solutions, Easy PhotoPrint EX. The user interface of the printer is quite user friendly. Printer is ideally suited for home and SoHo users.

Performance

The iP3680 prints at a decent speed, neither too fast, nor too slow as compared to the other printers. It took around 30.9 seconds for a quality mixed document print where as an economy print took 22 seconds. Quality of the print was quite satisfactory. In the photo tests it performed decently, specially in Photo 3 which was a portrait shot of